

have to travel and need people to stay there and make sure the pool guy can get in and that their dogs receive all the affection they need. Rough, right? As with the other home-sharing and -sitting options, though, responsible individuals only need apply.

10. Pay-as-you-go construction

This can be a long, time-consuming process depending on your current income level. Be prepared to suck it up with some seriously extreme frugality options when it comes to your lifestyle, but there's no reason all the renovation and remodeling needs to be done all in one shot.

11. Buy small, pay off early

The smaller the mortgage, the more rapidly you have a chance to pay it off. Go with a shorter mortgage, making extra payments at least once a year. This can happen very quickly if you are disciplined. After the payoff, you can enjoy where you are without over-head, or take any profit from the sale to pay cash for your next place if the market affords you that option.

12. Anchors away

For those of you who haven't explored the living-on-a-boat option—

it's come a long way. Go with a small houseboat, or purchase a larger out-of-service barge from a ship broker and have the whole thing converted into a floating loft. This is a great way to get waterfront living ability in places a young professional might not otherwise be able to afford. Think of every posh waterfront city you might want to live in and thought you could only drool over the possibility. You'll need a bit of cash up front for this option, but that amount can flex depending on the type of vessel you buy. I've also seen time-shares of these living spaces sold for certain times of year when the owners travel. It's a way to get back your cost fairly quickly if you are moored in an expensive location. If you are willing to think outside of the box, you can get a really cool place this way. You can also have these towed to a new location if you get sick of your current one.

So there you have it—12 ways to gain independence from the traditional rent and mortgage scene. Some may seem extreme. Some may take a tiny bit longer than you had hoped. Let me say this: I never promised you a rose garden. Financial independence does not come without serious self-discipline and at least certain periods of self-sacrifice. Be prepared to “suck it up” financially. That being said, financial independence in many